

Going Home with an Upper Respiratory Infection

A guide for your pet's recovery at home

Your pet was treated for an upper respiratory infection while in our care at the shelter. Signs may continue for a period of time after adoption as your pet finishes recovering. Please seek veterinary care if signs worsen or you have concerns.

What to Expect

- Signs such as sneezing, nasal or eye discharge, congestion, or a mild cough may continue for some time after adoption — this is normal as your pet continues to recover.
- The stress of moving to a new home can temporarily bring back or worsen signs, even if your pet was improving at the shelter.
- Most upper respiratory infections gradually improve over 1–2 weeks, though some pets take longer, especially cats.

Home Care

- Give all medications exactly as directed, even if your pet seems to be feeling better.
- Keep your pet in a warm, quiet, low-stress environment while they finish recovering.
- Gently wipe away nasal or eye discharge with a soft, damp cloth.
- Encourage eating — warmed or strong-smelling food can help if congestion is affecting appetite.
- A humidifier or a few minutes in a steamy bathroom can help ease congestion.

Contact Your Veterinarian If Your Pet Has:

- Not eating for more than 24 hours
- Labored or open-mouth breathing
- Thick, colored (yellow or green), or bloody discharge
- Lethargy, hiding, or seeming much worse rather than gradually improving
- Signs that continue beyond 2 weeks without improvement

Follow-Up Care

Schedule a follow-up visit with your veterinarian within **1–2 weeks** after adoption, or sooner if signs worsen or your pet stops eating.

Bring your adoption paperwork so your veterinarian knows what treatment was already given.